

State Legislative Aggregate Ideology Data January 2025 Update^{*}

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1 Introduction

The Shor-McCarty state legislative aggregate ideology data is being released as an update to the data underlying Shor and McCarty (2011). These are based on individual-level ideal point estimates (called “Shor-McCarty NPAT Scores” or “Shor-McCarty Common Space Scores”) described fully in that article. The updated data is described in Shor and McCarty (2022). We ask you to please cite both papers if you use our data.

Estimates are all in NPAT common ideological space to facilitate explicit comparisons across time and between states.

The data stretch from 1993 to 2022, newly incorporating the 2020 and 2021 state legislative elections, and filling in a portion of data missing in previous releases. There are now 2,730 aggregate chamber-year observations, compared with 2,519 in the last release.

As we do with each new release, the individual level data underlying this release has been extensively cleaned to minimize the random noise inherent in acquiring roll call votes from printed journals and online sources.

The newest version of the data and codebook can always be found on the American Legislatures web site (<https://americanlegislatures.com>) or Boris Shor’s Dataverse (<https://dataverse.harvard.edu/dataverse/bshor>). We are actively working on additional data, and will be releasing updated data sets over time.

2 Overview

Ideology and polarization estimates are measured at the chamber level. Not all state-years have measurements, due to the ragged availability of state legislative roll call data. The authors are actively working on additional data, and will be releasing updated data sets over time.

We generated bootstrapped error estimates for our scores at both individual and aggregate levels. At the individual level, we take advantage of the simulations that underlie the Bayesian IRT model to get a sense of the estimation uncertainty of legislator ideology in roll call space. We then simulate a large number of state-specific mapping coefficients for each state. Then, for each simulation of the legislator’s ideal point, we randomly draw (with replacement) one set of mapping coefficients, predicting an NPAT score each time. The

standard deviation of the simulations is our bootstrapped error estimate. At the aggregate level, we get quantities of interest using the individual common space scores and their bootstrapped errors. For example, in each simulation, we calculate a chamber median. Iterating over a large number of simulations, we take the standard deviation of the simulated medians as our measure of aggregate uncertainty.

3 Codebook

`st`

State abbreviation

`alpha`

State code, alphabetical order

`fips`

State FIPS code

`icpsr`

State ICPSR code

`year`

Chronological Year

`*_chamber`

Whole chamber median, by chamber

`*_dem`

Democratic party median (or mean), by chamber

`*_rep`

Republican party median (or mean), by chamber

`*_majority`

Majority party median, by chamber

`*_minority`

Minority party median, by chamber

`*_diffs`

Distance between party medians, by chamber. Our preferred measure of polarization.

`*_distance`

Average distance between any two members, by chamber. This is an alternative, party-free, measure of polarization.

`*_dem_sd`

Democratic party heterogeneity, by chamber

`*_rep_sd`

Republican party heterogeneity, by chamber

`*_chamber_sd`

Whole chamber heterogeneity, by chamber

`*_dem_error`

Democratic party median error estimate, by chamber

`*_rep_error`

Republican party median error estimate, by chamber

`*_chamber_error`

Whole chamber median error estimate, by chamber

`*_majority_error`

Majority party chamber median error estimate, by chamber

References

- Shor, Boris and Nolan McCarty. 2011. “The Ideological Mapping of American Legislatures.” *American Political Science Review* 105(3):530–551.
- Shor, Boris and Nolan McCarty. 2022. “Two Decades of Polarization in American State Legislatures.” *Journal of Political Institutions and Political Economy* 3(3-4):343–370.